prosperous, and vie with one another in the practice of benevolence and righteousness.' The 'elegant carving and inlaid sculpture work' on the 'royal palace and halls in the midst of the city' of Patliputra were so sublime that, Faxian surmises, only heavenly spirits could have made them. However, by the time Xuanzang visited two centuries later, the Gupta Empire had collapsed and Patliputra had 'long been deserted', stripped down to 'only its foundation walls', and hundreds of Buddhist monasteries and Deva (i.e. Brahminical) temples lay in ruins. Modern archaeology has found only a tiny part of what remained even in Xuanzang's time.

Impressions of Social Life

According to Yijing, 'the first and chief difference between India and other nations is the peculiar distinction between purity and impurity'. He notes that the idea of clean and unclean foods and consecrating spaces for drinking, eating and sleeping is strong among both monks and laymen. People fuss a lot over the protocols of handling food and utensils. After meals, they wash hands and rinse their mouths before touching others to avoid defiling them. Xuanzang too observed that people are 'very particular in their personal cleanliness'. They wash themselves before eating and do not share dishes or eat leftovers.

Such logic, Yijing suggests, led monastic kitchens to also keep out female servants (in case they were menstruating?), though he doesn't say how this was handled in nunneries. He offers clues on this question elsewhere, when he writes that 'nuns in India are very different from those in China. They support themselves by begging food, and live a poor and simple life'. Perhaps, unlike the monks, the nuns didn't have a kitchen in their residential quarters at all. Yijing's remarks apply to Indian Buddhist monasteries in general, and there is no reason to think that his alma mater, Nalanda Mahavihara, was any different. Scholars, however, still have few reliable specifics about the life of nuns in ancient Buddhist monasteries in India.

None of the three Chinese monks mention caste distinctions inside the monasteries. But what about the world outside? According to modern genomic research, endogamy was already common seventy generations ago, at least 'among upper castes and Indo-European speakers', so it existed